

Windows CLI Basics (Explore what windows CLI is, how to navigate, and interact with system using windows CLI).

Task 1 :- Introduction

In previous linux CLI basic room, you took your first step into linux command line.

Today you're continuing your journey, but this time on windows.

* Windows is one of the most widely used operating systems in workplace worldwide.

* In this room you'll learn how to use windows command prompt to navigate files, search for information and gather basic system details.

* As security perspective, windows is most important because many real world attacks and investigations involve windows system.

What is the windows command line?

The command prompt (often referred as CMD) is text based interface for interacting with windows operating system. Instead of clicking folders and menus, you type commands to tell the system exactly what you want to do, such as listing files, moving between folders, or checking system information.

Learning objectives :-

By the end of this room, you will be able to:

- * use windows command line correctly
- * navigate folders without clicking.
- * Find files when you only know their name
- * Read files using terminal
- * Collect basic system and network information.

Storyline 1- Day 2 on the job

You arrive for second day of your internship. Your supervisor greets with quick update.

Today we're switching windows, most of our machines run it. Same idea as before: I've left you a few tasks to attend to around the system. Use the command line to find them.

Task 2 :- Navigating files and finding your first file

A quick recap about terminal: —

Terminal is text based Interface for interacting with windows OS. Instead of clicking windows and folders, you type commands that tell computer exactly what to do. Cybersecurity professionals use it because.

• It's faster than clicking around | It gives more control | Many security tools only run in terminal.
• click Terminal file present on Desktop (Command prompt).

Overview: —

Before you explore anything on windows system, you need to know how to move around and look for files using command line. In this task, you'll learn how to explore folders, move between directories, search for file when you don't know where it is, read contents of text file, using Command prompt.

Task: — Find the mission-brief.txt file

Your boss has left you another note, with a task to find task-brief.txt file: —

Note: — I've left a file called task-brief.txt somewhere in your user folder. You'll need to find it using the command line and read what it says.

I've left file called task-brief.txt somewhere in user folder.

You're only given name of the file, not its location.

Let's explore how to navigate through windows filesystem using command line & how to locate a file without knowing its actual location.

Step 1: — Where Am I?

Before doing anything else, open the terminal on Desktop, and check your current location by typing command `cd`, as shown below.

```
C:\Users\Administrator> cd
```

→ output

```
C:\Users\Administrator
```

This shows full path of directory you're currently in. On windows this is usually your user folder. please

note `cd` command is also used to change directory. which we will use later in the task.

Step 2:- What's Around me?

Now, list the contents of current directory using command: `dir`

This command will list down the files and folders present in current directory, as shown below.

```
C:\Users\Administrator>dir
Volume in drive C has no label.
Volume Serial Number is ABA4-C362

Directory of C:\Users\Administrator

11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          .
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          ..
03/04/2024  10:17 AM  <DIR>          .ms-ad
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          .research
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          3D Objects
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Contacts
11/04/2026  10:23 PM  <DIR>          Desktop
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          Documents
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          Downloads
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Favorites
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Links
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Music
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Pictures
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Saved Games
2/26/2024  01:49 AM  <DIR>          Searches
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Videos
               0 File(s)              0 bytes
               16 Dir(s)  3,022,721,024 bytes free
```

You'll see files and folders that are visible by default. From the output, we can see that command has 16 directories.

Step 3:- Are the hidden files?

Some files and folders on windows are marked as hidden, which means they don't appear in normal listing. To show everything, including hidden items, run `dir /a`

```
C:\Users\Administrator>dir /a
Volume in drive C has no label.
Volume Serial Number is ABA4-C362

Directory of C:\Users\Administrator

11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          .
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          ..
03/04/2024  10:17 AM  <DIR>          .ms-ad
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          .research
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          3D Objects
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Contacts
11/04/2026  10:23 PM  <DIR>          Desktop
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          Documents
11/04/2026  10:14 PM  <DIR>          Downloads
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Favorites
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Links
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Music
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Pictures
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Saved Games
2/26/2024  01:49 AM  <DIR>          Searches
10/14/2022  10:06 AM  <DIR>          Videos
               0 File(s)              0 bytes
               16 Dir(s)  3,022,721,024 bytes free
```

The output clearly indicates that more than 12 hidden folders were found. It's more important to note that hidden doesn't mean secret. It just means windows hides them by default.

Step 4:- Moving around the file system :-

we use `cd` command to navigate through the folders. we can use format

`cd folder-name` to move to specified folder. The command `cd documents` will move

us to the Documents folder, as shown below. To move back one level, we can use `cd ..`

C:\Users\Administrator>cd documents ①

C:\Users\Administrator\Documents>cd .. ②

C:\Users\Administrator

To become familiar with environment, we use `dir` or `dir /a` command to move to see what's inside each folder.

Step 5:- Finding the File on the Disk

Instead of guessing where file is, let windows search for it. Use following command:

`dir /S task_brief.txt` . The `/S` flag tells windows to search all subfolders starting from your

Current directory and show you full path if file exists.

```
C:\Users\Administrator> dir /s task_brief.txt
Volume in drive C has no label.
Volume Serial Number is A8A4-C362

Directory of C:\Users\Administrator\Documents\
01/04/2026  10:14 PM                220 task_brief.txt
               1 File(s)                220 bytes

Total Files Listed:
               1 File(s)                220 bytes
               0 Dir(s)  5,278,261,248 bytes free
```

As we can see, the command above helped us locate the file and provided its full path.

Step 6:- Navigate to the File

Now that we know where file is located, let's use `cd` command to navigate to folder

using command `cd <path-to-the-task-brief.txt>` . use `dir` again to confirm that

`task-brief.txt` is in the folder, as shown below:

```
C:\Users\Administrator> cd C:\Users\Administrator\Documents\
C:\Users\Administrator\Documents> dir
Volume in drive C has no label.
Volume Serial Number is A8A4-C362

Directory of C:\Users\Administrator\Documents\
01/04/2026  10:14 PM                220 task_brief.txt
               1 File(s)                220 bytes
               0 Dir(s)  5,276,647,424 bytes free
```

Step 7:- Read the file

Now read the contents of file using: type `task-brief.txt` . This will print the contents of file directly in Command prompt as shown below:

```
C:\Users\Administrator\Documents\Notes> type task_brief.txt
Vice work getting into the Windows command line.

Your next tasks:
- Identify who you are logged in as
- Check the computer name
- Find the Windows version
- Check the machines IP address

FLAG
```

perfect .
you have not only learned how to navigate windows directory using CLI, but also how to find files and read their contents.

The content `task_brief.txt` leads us to our next task:-